



From Erving to Goffman

A Work in Performance?

Yves Winkin

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Goffman in the Open Series

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*Yves Winkin &
Wendy Leeds-Hurwitz*

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PART TWO

Goffman on Stage

In US academia, invitations to give a talk, particularly as a keynote speaker, are highly valued and diligently listed on a CV. Such events include not only lectures within academia but also outside it—for example, at a Rotary Club. Talks of this type are typically listed as “community service,” which refers to projects encouraged, if not required, by university administrators as a way to share knowledge with the surrounding communities. They are part of a tradition of public discourse dating back to the religious origins of the first universities in the US, which have always offered speaking courses to their students: The aim is not so much to study speeches as to write them and participate in oratorical jousts—a process that led to the creation of speech departments in the nineteenth century and communication departments in the twentieth (Winkin, 2004).

Goffman was a frequent public speaker, whether at conferences, symposia, or debates with colleagues. But he confined himself to the academic arena; he never entered the public lecture circuit and refused all media activity. He declined all requests for interviews, and almost all requests for photographs. Hence his aura of a secretive, home-bound hermit. Despite this, he actually moved around a lot, first within the United States, then in Europe. And he meticulously prepared his presentations. In 1985, when I interviewed Aaron Cicourel, who knew Goffman well, he told me the following: “He was a master of very theatrical, very prepared lectures. . . . He always gave a big performance, even for his graduate students at Berkeley. I went to so many colloquia with him. Always a powerful performance. And he was very careful about his preparation, very careful.”¹

¹ Interview in Paris, April 18, 1985.

One thing seems certain: Goffman hardly moved during his lectures; instead, he stood behind the desk and did not improvise. His “powerful performance,” to use Cicourel’s words, rather arose from his commitment to the subject, his vocal and visual intensity, his bodily tension—in a word: his presence.² The “power” of his lectures undoubtedly rested on the fact that they were long, dense, full of quotations and slides. But these same characteristics could have made them perfectly soporific. So how did Goffman hold his audience? We should not expect precise answers, as data are scarce. As mentioned previously, no audio or audiovisual recordings seem to have been made, or at least none have survived. On the basis of interviews and documents, I have only been able to reconstruct atmospheres, without ever succeeding in detailing the specific content of his lectures or grasping his oratorical techniques. That is, except for one: his distancing himself from photographers. Strangely enough, his presentations were not even listed on his CV.³

“He Trashed Me”

Goffman’s oral career began in Winnipeg at St. John’s Technical High School, in the debate tournaments seemingly organized by every school on the North American continent. The aim was to train students in the art of argumentation in a practical way: The teacher asked a question, leading to two diametrically opposed responses. A pupil adopted a position, defended it, and attacked that of his classmate. This is how Brian Burke once faced Erving Goffman on the question: “Which is better: coffee or tea?” Brian took the position defending tea; Erving defended coffee. He was so fierce in his criticism of Brian’s arguments in favor of tea that Brian preferred to admit defeat: “He trashed me.”⁴ This is one of Goffman’s traits that all who knew him have emphasized: intensity and the will to win at all costs, whether in a contest of oratory, tennis, or cards.

“Don’t Behave as if We Shouldn’t Respect You”

In October 1956, Goffman was invited to the prestigious Macy Conferences at Princeton University, at the suggestion of Ray Birdwhistell, his former

² On “presence” in the theater, see the anthology of definitions compiled by Josette Féral (2012, pp. 27–40.)

³ At least in the one he sent me on April 3, 1980.

⁴ Interview with Brian Burke in Winnipeg, May 30, 1991.

professor. This was a very closed circle, in which some twenty leading figures in the social sciences were invited to discuss a given theme with each other over several days (Winkin, 1984). Discussions were recorded, transcribed, reread by their authors, and published. Between 1954 and 1958, meetings were devoted to “group processes.” Among the 1956 guests were Gregory Bateson, Margaret Mead, and Frieda Fromm-Reichmann. During his talk, Goffman used the word “disgorgement” to refer to the discharge of patients from psychiatric hospitals. Several psychiatrists were in the room, and they began to get agitated. Mead became their spokesperson: “Disgorgement means vomiting. Is that what you mean?” (Goffman, 1988, p. 119). At first, Goffman gave the impression of retreating, but with a few well-turned phrases, he then sent his opponents back on the ropes. Frank Fremont-Smith, the symposium director, pretended that everything was finally back to normal, but behind the scenes he chastised Goffman: “Mr. Goffman, you wouldn’t be here if we didn’t respect you. Now, don’t behave as if we shouldn’t respect you.”⁵

What is less well-known is that, in the evenings, some of the participants got together to play poker. Goffman played very well, but very hard—with such intensity that Birdwhistell withdrew from the game.⁶ Then Alex Bavelas proposed a game of his own invention: “Goodbye, sucker.”⁷ The aim was to form an alliance with a partner, then betray him or her. Goffman loved it.

The participants apparently didn’t hold Goffman’s raging behavior against him: Two years later, he was invited back to Princeton. In the group photo, he looks cute in his bow tie and suit pocket.⁸

“Mrs. Frederickson, Don’t Be So Nostalgic”

From the late 1950s onwards, Goffman had to give lectures and seminars. These are scenes that need to be mentioned, since he found himself performing in them as he did in his public lectures. The testimonies of his former Berkeley students are consistent. Goffman carefully prepared his lectures: notes, annotated readings, slides—no long, threadbare digressions to pass the time, nothing but facts, references, and projected images to comment

⁵ Remarks reported by Ray Birdwhistell in an interview with YW on May 14, 1985.

⁶ Interview with Ray Birdwhistell, May 14, 1985.

⁷ In French, this could be translated as “Casse-toi, pauvre con.” Any connection with a well-known personality is deliberate.

⁸ See photo in insert after p. 19. Recognized, among others, are: Margaret Mead (first row, third from left), Konrad Lorenz (first row, fourth from right), Erving Goffman (first row, second from right), and Ray Birdwhistell (third row, third from right).

on. Goffman was a true professional, serious and dedicated to his science. He would arrive at the podium with his arms full of books, from which he would read excerpts. There were few gestures, no long and wide movements, no informality or casual conversations with students. In fact, he was not “Erving” to anyone, despite the relaxed, informal air of the times; rather, he was “Mr. Goffman” to everyone. Despite all his poise, however, there were occasions when his moodiness broke through. For instance, when a student attending his 1962 post-graduate seminar on “social contracts” dared to point out that he had just contradicted himself, Goffman stopped. The students froze. He remained silent for a few moments, then responded to the student: “Mrs. Frederickson, don’t be so nostalgic.”⁹ Much later, at the University of Pennsylvania, at the very start of the fall 1976 seminar, he asked students whose names were not listed on the door to leave the room. In other words, they were not being admitted to the course. The result was silence and stares, and no one was sure how serious he was. Goffman told them: “Look, I have a queen, I know what the law is and I obey orders.” None of the students, me included, immediately understood what a queen had to do with his admonition. It was only later that I understood that he was referring to the Queen of England, still the supreme authority in Canada, and he was still her subject. His sense of humor is the measure of the distance he always kept from his students. According to Dean MacCannell, who attended a Goffman seminar at Penn in 1970, he could go so far as to make fun of his students without them even realizing it:

As the students shifted back and forth between actually learning something and total incomprehension, Goffman would drop a few hints about what they should have read but obviously hadn’t. Then he would engage in often outrageous behavior that went straight over their heads. Fancifully false attributions they should have easily caught, etc. He and I entered into a silent conspiracy not to mark or in any way reveal his frame shifting. Sometimes the jokes were so funny it was difficult to suppress laughing out loud. Once afterwards I told him that I was “appalled” at his behavior, but even more appalled at the ignorance and/or timidity of his graduate students that enabled him. He gave me one of the biggest smiles I ever got from anyone.¹⁰

But it is possible that Goffman took advantage of the exceptional presence of a young colleague to indulge in these antics that year, and that his attitude

⁹ Interview with Dave and Vera Frederickson, March 14, 1987.

¹⁰ Email from Dean MacCannell, December 29, 2021.

toward his students was otherwise more benign. The memories of other students who took part in his seminars in the 1970s reveal a much different picture: that of a teacher who was certainly very demanding (with a huge list of compulsory readings), but also very respectful, very professional. Stuart Sigman, who attended his seminar on “Social Interaction” in the spring of 1979, recalls: “I always felt that, for Goffman, the classroom was a rehearsal for his writing. He generally had a manuscript in front of him, though he didn’t read it out loud so much as choose particular paragraphs to recite and then either illustrate with video or other data, or in some other way flesh out.”¹¹ But he did welcome questions at the end of class, and invited students to continue discussion either in his office or at a meeting in his home. He took them very seriously as future colleagues.

Thus, we have two very different portraits of Professor Goffman.

“Mr. Harwood, My Member May be Old”

When Ted Harwood heard Goffman’s formulation on the phone, he did not understand its double meaning, which was later explained to him by a colleague: “Mr. Harwood, although my member may be old, my filiation has not withered.”¹² It was in these terms that Goffman agreed to give a lecture in the early 1960s to students in the Sociology Department at the University of Chicago, at the invitation of Ted Harwood, a doctoral student in sociology. Every year, a colloquium was organized by the students; it was tradition at Chicago. Goffman presented “Symbols of Class Status” there in 1949, and so it was expected that he would give the opening lecture a few years later. What was less standard was his request to the organizers: no journalists in the room. The organizers understood the reason for this when they discovered that, under the title “A Random Walk Through a Social Organization,” Goffman wanted to talk about his fieldwork in Nevada casinos. The expression “random walk” comes directly from the world of casinos: This is the moment when everything can change—the player can lose everything as well as win everything. He just has to keep on playing, as if walking on a tightrope, and hope that luck will finally be on his side. Goffman explains this oscillation in detail in “Where the Action Is” (Goffman, 1967,

¹¹ Email from Stuart Sigman, December 30, 2021.

¹² All the information comes from a letter from Ted Harwood to YW, dated December 30, 1991, and an interview with him in Boston on January 14, 1992. It was David Riesman who suggested I get in touch with his former student, a professor at Boston University who specializes in casinos.

pp. 149–270). But in his talk to students in Chicago, he was less interested in explaining probability than in offering an ethnographic description of the atmosphere in casinos, which was based on contempt for gamblers, whom the staff regarded as “degenerates.” Casinos, Goffman suggested, are based on “the administration of deprivations to their clientele,” which he went on to compare to “the deprivations . . . of other institutions, such as Buchenwald or Dachau.”¹³ Goffman could have proposed that casinos are total institutions, like psychiatric hospitals. Instead, he compared them directly to concentration camps. That is an example of how much leeway he allowed himself, when he felt confident, in expressing himself brutally. It is true that Goffman cultivated strong formulations in his writings. But he did not take any risks other than rhetorical ones; he titillated his readers, and they loved it. Nevertheless, one can imagine the serious trouble he might have faced if any of his comments from this talk had been channeled back to the Mafia bosses who controlled the casinos at the time.

In this one example, we see the emergence of a pattern that would be confirmed over the years: If he felt in no way threatened by his audience, Goffman could be charming, humorous, even daring in what he said. At his Chicago lecture, he was surrounded by students who must have soaked up his words; and so, he let loose. Whereas when he spoke at Princeton, he was confronted by mostly hostile colleagues; as a result, he reared back. But beware: One Goffman can always hide another.

“Can We Get Erving to Make a Magnificent Peroration and Then Have a Discussion?”¹⁴

In 1964, the organizers of a three-day colloquium at the Institute of International Studies of the University of California at Berkeley were more political scientists than sociologists, but they did incorporate into the title a formulation that Goffman had provided to them as a member of the preparatory committee: “Strategic Interaction and Conflict” (Archibald, 1966). All the contributors were heavyweights, including a future Nobel Prize winner, Thomas Schelling; a future hero of the fight against the war in Vietnam, Daniel Ellsberg—who would go on to reveal the “Pentagon Papers” to the

¹³ The items in quotation marks are also in quotation marks in the letter cited in note 12, meaning that they are phrases formulated by Goffman and noted on the fly by Ted Harwood.

¹⁴ Sentence pronounced by the session chairman, Frederick Balderston, who was trying to get Goffman to end his speech quickly (quoted in Jaworski, 2023, p. 98n59).

world—and one of the discreet high priests of American nuclear philosophy, Albert Wohlstetter. Goffman embarked on a lengthy analysis of the relevance of the notion of communication for thinking about strategy and conflict. He was interrupted by both Ellsberg and Wohlstetter, who felt that he was discussing the sex of angels (while they were coordinating with military strategists on the best way to use an atomic bomb). While the chairman sought to move on to a more general discussion (“Can we get Erving. . .”), Goffman continued to debate his critics, unimpressed by their status. It was as if Goffman was still facing his high-school classmate, defending the virtues of coffee against those of tea.

*“What Do You Want Me to Do, Max,
Fall on My Knees and Pray?”*

In 1966, Goffman accepted an invitation from Manchester University to give the Simon Lectures to the Department of Sociology and Anthropology. The visit lasted six weeks. He arrived with his son Tom, age 13.¹⁵ Anthropologist Max Gluckman, the department’s tutelary figure, greeted him with a standard welcome: “Well, Erving, we’re very glad you’re coming to work with us.” Goffman’s response: “What do you want me to do, Max, fall on my knees and pray?”¹⁶ The collective narrative that would be passed around the department was that Goffman was unpleasant to everyone: aloof, ostentatiously reading *The Financial Times* to check the stock market, spending his time at the Salford casino, arguing with waitresses in restaurants. He gave four three-hour lectures, insisting on the importance of fieldwork, not hesitating to shock the students from time to time: “If you have to sleep with them, sleep with them.” Despite this tense atmosphere, he had a huge impact on the intellectual evolution of the department. At the time, he was still collaborating with Harold Garfinkel, who would publish *Studies in Ethnomethodology* the following year. He was also very familiar with Harvey Sacks, whose thesis he had supervised for many years at Berkeley. He introduced the department’s young sociologists (Wes Sharrock, John Lee, Rod Watson) to ethnomethodology and recommended them to Garfinkel, who visited Manchester in 1972–1973. The testimony of Wes Sharrock—a historical pillar of the department who remained there for over fifty years—is interesting to quote in this respect:

¹⁵ Interview with Rod Watson, January 10, 1993.

¹⁶ Interview with Wes Sharrock, January 10, 1993.

Shortly after I went to the Manchester University in the mid-1960s to do post-graduate work, Goffman visited the department for several weeks. One of the papers he presented was an introduction to what was to become *Frame Analysis* (1974). In the course of those fascinating talks, Goffman made complimentary mention of the work of Harold Garfinkel and Harvey Sacks. I had previously encountered Garfinkel's work but had never heard of Sacks. The latter sounded interesting because, according to Goffman, he was developing an account of interactional sequencing. . . . Goffman's recommendation I felt had to be taken seriously. . . . Whoever Sacks was, I was certainly going to find out what he was doing. (Sharrock, 1999, p. 120)

It is therefore safe to say that Goffman's visit to the Sociology Department at the University of Manchester in 1966 was integral to the department's emergence as the heart of ethnomethodological and conversational analysis research in the 1970s and 1980s, however dysphoric Goffman proved to be during that stay. In terms of its impact on Goffman's career, this first stay in Europe can be credited with establishing his double-sided reputation: powerfully original intellectually, but personally off-putting. It was undoubtedly after this stay in Manchester that the rumor of an unmanageable Goffman began to spread throughout the international sociological community. Whereas, in fact, Goffman was (almost) always kind to those who invited him. Almost always.

*"After This, There Will Be No More Photos"*¹⁷

In early 1970, Goffman agreed to give—for an honorarium of \$4,000¹⁸—the Fenton Lectures at the State University of New York at Buffalo (SUNY Buffalo). These lectures were widely recognized and well attended by the university community in and around the city. As Goffman explained in a letter to his hosts, he would give "three lectures on the rules employed to produce different senses of reality, the transformation of one sense into

¹⁷ Information supplied by Rod Watson in an email on January 14, 2022.

¹⁸ It should be pointed out that Goffman paid his own way. But the fact remains that \$4,000 in 1970 would be equal to \$33,400 in 2026. In 1968, the University of Pennsylvania paid Goffman an annual salary of \$30,000. The \$4,000 figure was specified in a letter from the university's director of cultural affairs, addressed to Goffman on September 26, 1969. A copy was kindly sent to me by William Offhaus, reference archivist at the University at Buffalo, along with six photos taken on February 16, 1970, at the start of Goffman's first lecture.

another, and the alienating consequences of these organizational features.”¹⁹ He also specified the theme of each lecture: “Codes, modes and fabrications”; “Techniques of production”; “Limits of frames and vulnerabilities of framing.”

The three presentations were held on February 16, 17, and 23 at 8:30 p.m. At the first lecture, the room was packed. Several press photographers approached Goffman as he took his place at the lectern. He gave them a stern look and said: “Okay, you’ve got three minutes to take all the photos you want. After that, there will be no more photos.” His tone made it clear that he was not joking. Flashbulbs popped as Goffman posed, both hands on the lectern. He was wearing an impeccable suit, complete with pocket handkerchief, tie, and button-down shirt.²⁰ Very chic. But then a photographer arrived a few moments late and tried to take a picture of Goffman just as he was about to launch into his talk. Goffman interrupted himself, stepped down from the podium and ran straight at the photographer: “I can either give a talk or pose for pictures. I can’t do both at the same time.” The photographer was so upset that he dropped his flash, which shattered on the floor.²¹ After this, Goffman returned to the stage and began his long lecture, which lasted almost two hours. No one moved. And no photographer showed up for the other two lectures. There were also slightly fewer people in attendance.

“Today, I Can Organize Symposiums with Wenner-Gren Funds”

From August 31 to September 4, 1970, Goffman was co-chairman, with Thomas Sebeok, the big boss of American semiotics, of a highly international colloquium in Amsterdam on the “ethology of interactions,” financed by the prestigious Wenner-Gren Foundation.²² This was a serious endeavor. The list of participants reads like a who’s who of the field at the time: Gregory Bateson, Irenäus Eibl-Eibesfeldt, Paul Ekman, Adam Kendon, Desmond

¹⁹ Letter from EG to the Cultural Affairs Department of SUNY Buffalo, dated October 2, 1969.

²⁰ See photo in insert after p. 19.

²¹ Incident reported on January 16, 2022, by Tom Weinberg to Rod Watson, with whom he attended all three conferences. Tom Weinberg has vivid memories of the flash crashing to the ground.

²² The Wenner-Gren Foundation, named after its founder, a Swedish industrialist who made his fortune in door-to-door Electrolux vacuum cleaner sales, has been funding research in anthropology and archaeology since 1941. Established in New York, it had a European base between 1958 and 1980 at Burg Wartenstein Castle in Austria. For further details, see Susan Lindee and Joanna Radin (2016, pp. 218–301).

Morris, Kenneth Pike, Harvey Sacks, etc. (Sherzer, 1971). Ray Birdwhistell, the founder of kinesics, was not present, but W. John Smith, a relatively unknown ethologist from the University of Pennsylvania, was there, and he was one of Goffman's main sources of information on ethology.²³ As co-chairman, Goffman was asked to summarize the discussions on the final day. He proposed a research program for the ethology of interactions, close to the themes that would appear a year later in *Relations in Public* (Goffman, 1971). He moved away from classical sociology, calling on anthropology, linguistics, and ethology, but without adopting a visionary stance, simply assuming a very concrete empirical approach.

Goffman must have already understood that his international stature was on the rise. In a conversation with him in April 1980, I mentioned his participation in the 1956 Macy Conferences at Princeton with Bateson, Mead, and Birdwhistell. But he immediately replied, without raising his voice: "Those were cowboys, freaks, stray dogs talking to stray dogs." The phrasing was harsh; perhaps he still remembered his heated discussion with Mead and certain psychiatrists. But what he really meant was that the participants in the Macy Conferences were disciplinary exiles, whereas he had always gotten positions in the heart of the discipline. The result was that he could now organize colloquia with Sebeok, funded by Wenner-Gren. In other words, he was in a position of power, or at least had entered certain academic circles of power.²⁴

One of these circles revolves around Burg Wartenstein, the twelfth-century Austrian castle that the Wenner-Gren Foundation bought and renovated in the late 1950s to hold residential symposia lasting at least a week (in a spirit reminiscent of those held at Cerisy in Normandy). Between 1958 and 1980, eighty "symposia" were held there under the guidance of Lita Osmundsen, a New Yorker with great social skills, who loved to create a refined atmosphere in "her" château: elegant meals, musical evenings, walks in the park. She watched over every interactional detail:

She was watching who directed comments to whom, paying attention to the rate of exchange, and particularly noticing the danger signs when someone was becoming marginalized. One of her observations was that a person who said

²³ Goffman suggested that I audit Smith's course at the Philadelphia Zoo, to learn how to observe monkeys in order to establish their ethogram.

²⁴ Pierre Bourdieu had discovered to his amazement that Goffman, whose name he had suggested for an invitation to join the Institute for Advanced Study in Princeton, where he himself was a fellow in 1972, was still considered a marginal figure by many of the leading lights of American sociology (letter to YW, ca. 1980).

nothing for the first day of the conference was unlikely to speak much for the rest of it, so Osmundsen introduced protocols that required everyone to speak on the first day. She also learned to watch for signs of an incipient rebellion and to intervene when necessary. (Lindee & Radin, 2016, p. 261)

The château had only forty rooms, so guests were hand-picked. Goffman was invited twice, in September 1970 and August 1974. Apart from a mention of his name in the list of participants, there is no trace of his presentation at the first colloquium, organized by George De Vos and Theodore Schwartz under the title “Ethnic Identity: Cultural Continuity and Change.” It sounds like Margaret Mead’s style—and, indeed, she was present. Only the castle walls could tell whether Lita had to mediate her exchanges with Goffman. By contrast, for the second colloquium, “Secular Rituals,” organized by Max Gluckman, Sally Moore, and Victor Turner (Moore & Myerhoff, 1977), we have the group photo, at the château entrance.²⁵ Goffman is in the front row, far left; he’s not looking at the photographer but at the other participants. He has his hands in his pockets, appearing very relaxed. He’s wearing a light-colored suit made of a lightweight fabric, with a dark pocket square to match his polo shirt. Twenty years have passed between the stilted attitude in the Princeton photograph and this one. He is clearly not the same man.

“His Notes Would Shake as He Talked”

The arena in which Goffman was to perform most regularly from the 1950s to the 1970s was that of the great annual professional conventions of North American sociologists (American Sociological Association) and anthropologists (American Anthropological Association). On an almost fixed date, thousands of professors and doctoral students converge on a huge hotel in one of the major cities of the United States or Canada. There’s something Durkheimian about these highly ritualized gatherings, with their solemn opening speeches; their hundreds of timed presentations in rooms that are sometimes too large, sometimes too small, but often too cold and windowless; their noisy cocktail parties every evening; their basement book sales; and so on. Participants wear ribbons indicating their status within the association, search for each other all day long, and chat in front of the elevators, looking over their interlocutor’s shoulder to make sure they don’t miss anyone they know.

²⁵ See photo in the insert after p. 19.

It would undoubtedly be possible to locate in the archives of these two associations documentation for all of Goffman's participation and presentations, year after year. But that is not the point. Rather, we need to try to understand how Goffman "performed" there, in the sense that his persona as a mysterious sociologist increased. Even for Dan Rose, one of his former students and a colleague at the University of Pennsylvania's School of Architecture: "It was the only time of year when most of us could see him. The rest of the time, he was in seclusion."²⁶ As a result, his passages in the corridors were noticed and commented upon, especially if Goffman suddenly addressed a group of colleagues, as when he was heard saying: "If I can't find anybody more important to talk with, I will come back and talk with you" (Berger, 1973, p. 354). He was just as theatrical in a room or in the corridors as on the stage: He appeared, disappeared, was sought after, popped up, then left again. His persona was based on discretion. No hugs, no exclamations of reunion. A tap on the shoulder and he would be gone. This was his way of letting an old comrade know that he had recognized him. But Goffman did not go to annual conventions to socialize, to see his colleagues, do a bit of urban tourism and eat well.²⁷ He was there to participate in a scientific meeting, and he did so intensely—as he always did when he found himself behind a lectern: "His notes would shake as he talked; he was very serious about the professional business," says Dan Rose.²⁸

This can be discerned between the lines in his only surviving lecture, which exists in the form of a bootleg recording turned into a transcript published after his death (after approval by Gillian Sankoff): "On Fieldwork," which Goffman presented at the Pacific Sociological Association in 1974, at the invitation of John Lofland, one of his most loyal admirers (Goffman, 1989). Lofland had asked four colleagues (in addition to Goffman, they were Sherri Cavan, Fred Davis, and Jackie Wiseman) to speak spontaneously about their field experience in the first person. Did Goffman speak that day off

²⁶ Interview with Dan Rose in Philadelphia, April 22, 1991.

²⁷ That said, Goffman did not spend his evenings in his hotel room. Some of the people I spoke to mentioned his unpleasant behavior at convention parties, which must have contributed to his reputation as a strange character. In an interview in Philadelphia on January 21, 1998, Sam Kaplan remembered an ASA meeting in New Orleans at the end of August 1972, where sociologist Charles Page organized a party in his suite and invited Goffman, whom he didn't know personally. A knock at the door prompted Page to open. A small man stood in the doorway. "You must be Erving Goffman. Good evening, I'm Charles Page." Goffman: "I don't care who you are, I just want a drink." Page, who is tall and athletic, grabbed him by the sleeve: "Get out, you're not welcome here," and closed the door on Goffman.

²⁸ Interview with Dan Rose in Philadelphia, April 22, 1991.

the top of his head, letting ideas flow as they came? Probably not. Unlike his colleagues, who would illustrate their remarks with examples from their own fieldwork, Goffman would never mention Unst, St. Elizabeths, or Las Vegas. Instead, he set out general principles as he does in his writings, by enunciating the steps beforehand and then following them, which implies most likely having had notes in front of him. So Goffman did not speak in a ruffled manner. But he did nevertheless indulge in a few well-chosen formulations, which no doubt came to him in the moment: “Now the next thing you have to do is cut your life to the bone, as much as you can afford to cut it down” (Goffman, 1989, p. 127). In the same spirit, he became very concrete when describing integration into the community under study:

One thing is, you should feel you could settle down and forget about being a sociologist. The members of the opposite sex should become attractive to you. You should be able to engage in the same body rhythms, rate of movement, tapping of the feet, that sort of thing, as the people around you. Those are the real tests of penetrating a group. (p. 129)

Finally, there was his deadpan humor, found throughout his work. But in this context it was at times situated, considering, for example, the fact that his speech took place in California: “You have to stop making points to show how ‘smart ass’ you are. And that’s extremely difficult for graduate students (especially on the East Coast, especially in the East!)” (Goffman, 1989, p. 128). When Goffman uttered this phrase, the audience must have laughed; mockery is permanent between the two coasts, in all walks of life. We can see how, as an effective speaker, he built a complicity with an audience mostly coming from the West Coast, who knew that he lived on the East Coast, but also that he himself had lived on the West Coast for a long time. All speakers produce this kind of localized joke; even Goffman bent to the rule of the genre.

“We Don’t Eat Lunch at the Faculty Club”

While he began to draw crowds with his appearances at annual sociology and anthropology meetings, and was increasingly invited to Europe, Goffman still accepted numerous local invitations, many of which left no trace. For example, he gave three talks at the University of Tennessee in Knoxville.

In 1971, two professors, a sociologist and a philosopher, discovered a common interest in Goffman’s work, and decided to set up a double course

of annotated readings and to invite the author, who accepted,²⁹ quite simply. What's more surprising is that neither the sociologist, Tom Hood, nor the philosopher, Dwight Van de Vate, had a personal relationship with Goffman. Their university was one of the country's oldest (founded in 1794), but it was not well-known or particularly recognized. Yet Goffman flew to Knoxville and spoke to the students for several hours about *Frame Analysis*, his book-in-progress. His only request to his hosts was: not to have lunch at the university's Faculty Club.

The second visit, in the mid-1970s, was already more formal: a public lecture, in a room that can hold 180 people. The chairs were full, and people were standing. Goffman came with the slides that would soon become part of *Gender Advertisements*. Tom Hood then recounts an incident that had happened before (in Buffalo, among other places) and will happen again (in Rio de Janeiro, among other places):

Near the beginning of the lecture but before the slides of advertisement had started, a photographer for the student paper had the temerity to walk into the hall and began to take Goffman's picture without his permission. All of us remember Goffman stopping his presentation and sharply dismissing the photographer from the room without a picture. (Hood, 2017, p. 293)

Was Goffman creating extreme tension deliberately, to capture his audience's attention? Was he at the peak of his performance? Or was he simply trying to maintain a homogeneous frame for his lecture, while resisting the interference that would be induced by a photo shoot? Both interpretations are possible. But whatever his motivation, the cost of these interruptions was heavy: The conference had to be put back on track before it could proceed as planned.

For his third visit to Knoxville in the late 1970s, several departments mobilized to welcome Goffman. But a late plane was to disrupt the day's schedule. Goffman barely had time to swallow a sandwich before he found himself in a large, crowded amphitheater. His title: "The Social Psychology of the Conference." No incidents to report. Goffman won over his audience at the University of Tennessee's College of Liberal Arts and returned to Philadelphia.

²⁹ All my information comes from Tom Hood's afterword in Hood & Van de Vate (2017, pp. 291–294). I thank Greg Smith for bringing this work to my attention.

“Erving Let Everyone Know That I Should Be Promoted Soon”

The situation was much the same when Goffman visited the University of California, Davis, in 1975. He didn’t go to meet famous colleagues as he did at Burg Wartenstein; he quite simply went to do his “job” as an academic.

At the San Francisco airport, he rented a car to drive to Davis, only an hour and a half away. As usual, he took a VW Beetle, the only rental car he liked to drive. He hated American land yachts; he loved the nervous dryness of his Morgan. He went to stay with his host, Dean MacCannell, whom he had met at Berkeley as a student and then reconnected with in Philadelphia as a postdoc.³⁰ Dean was far from the tourism studies specialist he would become a few years later with his book *The Tourist*. He had just been hired by the University of California, Davis, but in the Faculty of Agriculture, not Sociology, a position at the bottom of the ladder in terms of prestige. He had yet to be tenured. So he was walking on eggshells. Goffman came to help him, but he did not want a big public event. Instead, he requested a small room holding no more than thirty people. He accepted a reduced fee of around \$500.³¹ The title he proposed was “Primary and Secondary Frames,” which is predictable given that he had published *Frame Analysis* the year before.

Before the conference, MacCannell informed Goffman that he had already passed on the message that recording would not be allowed. When they arrived at the room, they found not only students but also colleagues there, some of them from far away. Goffman said nothing: He let MacCannell introduce him, thanked him, and announced that he would be speaking for at least two hours, and that he would understand perfectly if some of them had to leave the room before the end. Goffman did not specify that he would not allow recordings. He then spoke for over two hours from his notes, regularly making eye contact with the audience. “I believe he scanned the room searching for at least one person in the audience who was actually understanding what he was talking about. If he found even just one person who was ‘getting’ what he was saying, he delivered a straightforward lecture with helpful asides and clarifications.”³² The lecture over, MacCannell took

³⁰ All information on Goffman’s two lectures at the University of California, Davis, comes from testimonials provided by Dean MacCannell (interview with YW, May 13, 1987; email correspondence with YW on December 28 and 29, 2021) and from the Erving Goffman Archives website curated by Dmitri Shalin (interview with Dean MacCannell, July 7, 2009). See note 3 in the Epilogue, p. 65.

³¹ In 2026 dollars, \$500 would be \$3,000.

³² Email from Dean MacCannell, December 29, 2021.

a dozen colleagues out for dinner at a local restaurant for the basics: pizza and beer. Half a dozen of them then met up at the department chair's house to continue chatting:

Everyone who was there after dinner knew Erving very well. The conversation was relaxed, spontaneous, no one dominating, no one hanging back, lots of topic switching, lots of laughs. Without banging the drum too hard, Erving let everyone know that I should be moved to tenure quickly. I don't know how much impact his words had, but I was granted tenure in the second year of my appointment.³³

At no time during his stay did Goffman express the slightest irritation or make any demands. He was surrounded by friends, not celebrities. His behavior was not unlike that of Michel Foucault at the Claremont Colleges, near Los Angeles, when he was invited in May 1975 by Simeon Wade, a young professor accompanied by his pianist friend, Michael Stoneman (Wade, 2021). With Wade's students and companions, he was perfectly approachable; with the teachers, he closed up and ran away.

Why did Goffman go to Davis in 1975? To discreetly support MacCannell, and to do a bit of promotion for *Frame Analysis*, of course, but what else? For the fee? Not likely: He had one of the highest salaries at the University of Pennsylvania, not to mention his stock market revenues. To test new ideas? Possibly. But in the absence of any written record of his presentation, that is very difficult to confirm or deny. For the pleasure of being on stage, feeling the attention of his audience, tasting once again the rush described by so many performing artists? That seems doubtful. Unlike his sister Frances, who made a career as a stage and screen actress, Erving had no love of the spotlight. So then we are left with one more possible motivation, which may seem surprisingly naive in the case of Goffman: that he believed in his discipline, that he had a crusader's faith in the scientific breakthrough represented by his approach to sociology, that he wanted to talk about it, defend it, get feedback. And for this "mission," he was ready to travel around the US and the world. This suggestion may not mesh with Goffman's reputation as a cynic, but that is precisely where Goffman the performer enters: He had this ability to split himself in two, sometimes appearing as an insufferable grouch, sometimes revealing himself as a dedicated researcher. The difficulty is that he remained unpredictable. Just because he was invited to a major international conference did not necessarily mean he would be pleasant.

³³ *Ibid.*

Nor did the fact that he might be put on a very small panel mean he would not spoil the mood. Germany provides a good case in point.

*“He Read His Paper with Utmost Speed and
Without Any Eye Contact with the Audience”*

Goffman was invited to Germany on several occasions: to Bielefeld in 1973, Constance in 1975,³⁴ Essen in 1978,³⁵ and Nuremberg in 1980.³⁶ A comparison of these four visits to the same country reveals a number of patterns in Goffman’s performances as a lecturer.

From April 5 to 8, 1973, Goffman was invited to an “international workshop” organized by a group of young professors at the brand new University of Bielefeld. They succeeded in attracting some forty-five well-known speakers, including Harold Garfinkel, Harvey Sacks, and John Gumperz, to present on the theme of “speech act theory and the ethnography of communication.” The university’s Center for Interdisciplinary Research funded the entire operation, even providing drivers for the speakers. Nevertheless, the atmosphere was pretty heavy. One of the participants, sociologist Ralph Bohnsack, recalls that Harvey Sacks’s presentation was difficult to understand, both because his terminology was so new and because the acoustics in the room were poor.³⁷ In addition, the stars were not very courteous to each other:

I am absolutely sure that Goffman’s talk was about *Frame Analysis* [more specifically] the frame analysis of talk (because the Bielefeld Conference was about sociology of language). We were especially curious because the book was not yet published. Goffman and Garfinkel were not so harmonious with each other (their former common doctoral student Harvey Sacks was also present), but they allied oneselves [*sic*] with caustic comments when [Thomas] Luckmann was talking. Garfinkel for instance commented as a reply that he himself just would be busy with a research [*sic*] about children’s talk and Luckmann’s way of talking would remind him to that [*sic*].³⁸

³⁴ Emails from Andrea Ploder, January 1 and 3, 2021.

³⁵ Emails from Jörg Bergmann, March 16 and August 5, 2021, and February 1 and 3, 2022.

³⁶ Emails from René Salomon, September 9 and 19, 2021.

³⁷ Emails from Ralf Bohnsack, March 17 and August 5, 2021.

³⁸ *Ibid.*

Bohnsack's overall impression of the event was that Goffman and Garfinkel were "aloof and somewhat arrogant."³⁹ This perception is not unlike that retained by many witnesses to Goffman's stay in Manchester. It was as if Goffman wanted to shake off the public's devotion by presenting himself in an unpleasant light. But as soon as he was no longer being observed, he once again donned the garb of a humble, pleasant person. Fritz Schütze, one of the organizers of the Bielefeld meeting, drew laughter when he recalled his encounter with Goffman in an interview with a colleague:

All these famous professors of qualitative research were very friendly and understanding to us, young German researchers. Goffman would come to Evi's and my little flat; he was extremely witty and at the same time very modest. He looked more like an American barkeeper (as far as I had an image on [sic] such an occupational type of person from American movies), and you would never imagine that this would be a very, very prominent professor of sociology. Being then a professor of [sic] the University of Pennsylvania in Philadelphia, he had an old beetle car with an impaired heating, and in Winter times [sic], he put a *Steinhager flask* with hot water, this kind of earthenware bottle, under his beetle seat in order not to get too icy. (Kazmierska, 2014, p. 307)

When you consider that Goffman also owned a Morgan, one of the rarest and most anachronistically sophisticated English sports cars on the market, you can see that he literally "played it modest" at Fritz Schütze's place. It has to be said, too, that Morgans are convertibles, not really suited to winter on the American East Coast.

Two years later, from June 23 to 26, 1975, Thomas Luckmann (who was very famous in Germany) and Richard Grathoff organized a seminar at the University of Konstanz. They invited an array of prestigious US sociologists to the Hotel Drachenburg: Aaron Cicourel, Erving Goffman, Emmanuel Schegloff, and Anselm Strauss (presented here in alphabetical order, not in order of appearance). The audience consisted of some thirty colleagues.⁴⁰ Goffman presented elements of his ongoing work on radio conversations.⁴¹ This time, the bad Goffman was the one who appeared:

He read his paper with utmost speed and without any eye contact with the audience. He made critical remarks after the presentation of others (especially after

³⁹ *Ibid.*

⁴⁰ Email from Jörg Bergmann, March 16, 2021.

⁴¹ This is "Radio Talk: A Study of the Ways of Our Errors," which would appear in *Forms of Talk* (pp. 197–327).

Schegloff) and seemingly had some knowledge of German sociology. His impression was that German sociology is bookish and remote from everyday life . . .⁴²

According to another participant, Alexandre Métraux, Goffman had made no effort to dress up. Shaggy, dressed in a rumpled T-shirt, “[he] looked like he’d just come out of a gym where he’d just finished a two-hour workout.”⁴³ This rebellious Goffman is the version we sometimes find when he was competing with colleagues whose research themes overlapped with his own. This was especially the case with Schegloff, whose analysis of “turn taking” in ordinary conversations has the gift of making Goffman tense, because he had recently become interested in the same topic yet approached it without the creativity of his younger colleague.

Despite his somewhat rocky relationship with his German (and North American) colleagues, Goffman was invited to Germany twice more. In 1978, he made a very discreet visit to Essen to receive the Prize for Research in Communication *In Medias Res*, funded by the Burda Group, one of Germany’s largest publishers (with six hundred titles at the time).⁴⁴ The prize consists of a cheque for twenty-five thousand marks, presented during a very formal ceremony at the Schloss Hugenpoet restaurant near Essen. A private publication was issued by the Burda Group, with two photos of Goffman in full regalia (Prince-de-Galles jacket, black tie, and heavy-rimmed glasses).⁴⁵ But he smiles as he shakes hands with the master of ceremonies. His talk, set against a backdrop of bouquets of flowers, is entitled “Picture Frames,” no doubt an adaptation of a chapter in *Gender Advertisements*, which was published in book form the following year. No details have been released about his attitude during the conference, but it seems likely he did not read his text at full speed with downcast eyes.

In February 1980, Goffman was again in Germany, this time at the University of Erlangen-Nürnberg for a symposium on biographical research, organized by Joachim Matthes, Arno Pfeifenberger, and Manfred Stosberg. In view of Goffman’s own reluctance to be the subject of a biography,⁴⁶ it

⁴² Email from Jörg Bergmann, March 16, 2021.

⁴³ Email from Alexandre Métraux, February 6, 2022.

⁴⁴ The prize appears to have been awarded only five times. Other recipients include Elihu Katz (1977), Karl Deutsch (1979), Serge Moscovici (1980), and Irenäus Eibl-Eibesfeldt (1981).

⁴⁵ I would like to thank Jörg Bergmann for scanning several pages of this impossible-to-find album for me. See the last two photographs in the insert after p. 19.

⁴⁶ See his letter to Irving Horowitz, dated July 2, 1976, as analyzed in the Epilogue (pp. 63–64).

may come as a surprise that he agreed to address this issue at a colloquium. But he had already discussed it in Constance in 1975 with colleagues whose work was essentially based on biographical reconstructions. He reunited with them in Erlangen, where the dialogue continued. Here we find Goffman totally committed to research for research's sake.⁴⁷ His talk was strangely entitled "Recognition." Of course, his text did not appear in the colloquium proceedings and, as if a devilish angel were watching, the recorder malfunctioned during his talk. All that remains is a fragment of recollection from one of the participants: "He only criticized the idea of biographical reconstruction for not taking into account the influence of the order of interaction in situation."⁴⁸ Sounds like Goffman.

"It's Fun, It's Cheap and You Can Drink Good Wine"

Pier Paolo Giglioli is a sociolinguist who studied with Goffman at Berkeley in 1967–1968. Paolo Fabbri is a semiologist who worked closely with Umberto Eco. The two Paolos invited Goffman to the International Center for Semiotics and Linguistics in Urbino, Italy, in July 1975. The center was founded in 1971 by Pino Paioni, one of Italy's first professors of semiotics. It soon became a summer meeting place for many Italian, French, and American intellectuals, from Louis Marin to Eliseo Veron, from Jean-François Lyotard to Michel de Certeau. Eco was a frequent visitor in the early 1970s. For the many post-graduate students who attended the lectures and seminars, it was a rather unique opportunity to rub shoulders with famous academics, who often proved to be open and relaxed, particularly at the "Semiotic Bar" at the foot of the road leading to the university, perched on the hill.

Goffman arrived with Joel Sherzer and his French-born wife, Dina Sherzer, who had a good grasp of local expectations.⁴⁹ He did not seem very comfortable in the happy hubbub of the center. He first presented a version of "Replies and Responses," which became the first chapter of *Forms of Talk* in 1981.⁵⁰ He read his text at full speed, maintaining his concentration, while

⁴⁷ It is perhaps worth noting that Goffman left an unfinished text on the notion of "personhood" (personal communication from Gillian Sankoff, April 1, 1986).

⁴⁸ Email from René Salomon, September 19, 2021.

⁴⁹ My two main sources of information are Paolo Fabbri (numerous informal discussions over the years since 1976) and Pier Paolo Giglioli (interview on May 8, 1992; informal exchanges in 2020–2021).

⁵⁰ "Replies and Responses" was pre-published in 1975 by the International Center for Semiotics and Linguistics at the University of Urbino in the form of a forty-two-page booklet. The center published such pre-publications every year, always in the same format

many listeners, or rather spectators, came and went as was customary in Urbino. But he did answer questions, taking care not to stray into unfamiliar linguistic or semiotic territory. He also attended other workshops, regularly asking questions, a bit like a good student, and not at all like a star trying to capture the spotlight. His second presentation was a classic: the slide carousel of images from *Gender Advertisements*, his “road show.”

Goffman did not take part in the center’s many parallel events. He was not seen at the Semiotic Bar; instead, he was seen wandering the streets of Urbino alone. In fact, he took an instant liking to the town, to the point of considering buying a house there: “It’s nice, it doesn’t cost much, and you can drink good wine.”⁵¹ This didn’t stop him from keeping an eye on the stock market; no sooner had he settled in Urbino than he wanted to know how to access the day’s figures. This was a constant for him. He had asked the same question in Manchester and would ask it again in Rio.

“He Said It Was an Invasion of His Privacy”

Goffman always traveled from west to east, with one exception of north to south, for a few days in Rio de Janeiro in October 1978. At the express request of Howard Becker, his fellow Chicagoan, and perhaps Thomas Szasz, also an old acquaintance,⁵² Goffman took part in the First International Symposium of the Brazilian Institute of Psychoanalysis, which was to launch an “anti-psychiatry” movement in Brazil through the combined efforts of representatives of the social sciences and psychoanalysts. Sitting around a large table were: Robert Castel, Félix Guattari, Franco Basaglia, Gilberto Velho, Erving Goffman, and Shere Hite, who became a feminist icon after her report on female sexuality, published in 1976 in the United States. Velho, whose sociological influence was immense in Brazil, recounts with amusement the incidents that punctuated Goffman’s talk, starting with the interruption of his lecture when a student tried to take a photo. According to Velho, Goffman claimed this was an invasion of his privacy. Howard Becker had to intervene to convince his old friend to resume his talk (Velho, 2002, p. 11). His colleagues were clearly intrigued by Goffman, with his frequent requests to be kept abreast of New York Stock Exchange prices. Velho would have liked him to give other lectures during his stay.

and layout.

⁵¹ Sentence reported by Pier Paolo Giglioli in an interview with YW on May 8, 1992.

⁵² Together, they had founded the Association for the Abolition of Involuntary Psychiatric Hospitalization in 1970.

Goffman, however, had other ideas, and fled before the symposium was over. Even so, Velho would talk for years about Goffman's visit to Rio,⁵³ helping to give it mythical status in Brazil.

"Let's Get Closer to the Tables, Otherwise We'll Get Screwed"

From the 1950s onwards, Goffman regularly visited London.⁵⁴ He saw Liz Bott again, sometimes alone, sometimes with Sky. He became a familiar face at the Tavistock Institute, where Liz worked. But his visit in September 1979, at the invitation of facial expression psychologist Paul Ekman, to take part in the NATO Advanced Study Institute on Nonverbal Behavior Research Methods, a massive convening held over two weeks at the University of London's Birkbeck College (Scherer & Ekman, 1982), was undoubtedly a professional first for him—and a huge challenge. Dozens of researchers and PhD students had come to attend seminars given by all the hallowed figures in the field, from Robert Rosenthal to Adam Kendon. Birdwhistell was the only one to miss out: He was very wary of Ekman's work and NATO's involvement in this sector.⁵⁵ Goffman, for his part, played the game: Not only did he give a highly technical lecture entitled "Participation Frameworks," but he also took part in various methodological discussions, during which he reiterated his refusal to work with interviews.⁵⁶ He did agree to be consulted by students, myself among them. We found him to be relaxed, but serious and committed, aware of the importance of the theoretical and methodological stakes involved in the encounter.

One memory that emerges from that time: While we were chatting among students after one of his talks, he spotted us heading for the exit. He came back to us, bag slung over his shoulder, and slipped into our group to repeat what he considered to be his essential message: Social interactions must not be confused with social relations; either you study one or the other, but you can't study one in order to study the other. And off he went again.

A second memory: I was chatting with him while waiting for the buffet to arrive; suddenly, he interrupted me and said: "Let's get closer to the

⁵³ In fact, we talked a lot about Goffman during our dinner in Rio on April 25, 1995.

⁵⁴ Goffman spoke at the University of Edinburgh in 1978, on the occasion of Tom Burns's retirement (email from Greg Smith, January 26, 2022). However, as information on his talk is too fragmentary, I have decided not to devote a segment to it.

⁵⁵ It was only with great reluctance that he agreed to write a letter of recommendation in support of Stuart Sigman's and my application to the institute.

⁵⁶ Goffman forbade Carole Gardner from conducting interviews as part of her thesis (Gardner, 1999, p. 63).

tables, otherwise we'll get screwed." It was practical Goffman as formulated by Goffman.

At the final party, he arrived well-dressed in a dark jacket and pressed pants, without a tie. He gently declined a student's request to take a photo of him, but nothing more. He strolled from group to group with a drink in hand. This is the confident Goffman spotted on several occasions in dialogue with students, from Davis to Knoxville. He even took part in the big group photo. But he was not in the middle of the front row with his colleagues. Instead, he stood at the far left, half in shadow, his head turned towards his neighbor, as if he wanted to blend in with the huge group.

*"Although the Titles of Some of the Lectures May
Appear a Bit Esoteric to the Uninitiated"*

Under the broad title of "Space, Sign, Subject in Literature, the Arts, and the Social Sciences," a group of professors from the French and Italian Departments at the University of California, Davis, invited an international line-up of academic celebrities to three "workshops" on March 7 and 8, 1980: from Rosalind Krauss to Paul de Man, from Michel de Certeau to Paolo Fabbri, from Goffman to Thomas Sebeok. Speakers were free to choose their topics, but their lectures were not to exceed forty-five minutes, including questions. In compensation, the fees were generous.⁵⁷ Lecturers from Europe represented "French Theory," which was then spreading to American universities with a mysterious air. Speakers from across the US represented the cutting edge of American social science. Indeed, the organizers took the precaution of specifying in the *California Aggie*, the weekly paper distributed on campus: "Although the titles of some of the lectures may appear a bit esoteric to the uninitiated, the organizers of the conference are ready to vouch that anybody with a keen interest in the assumptions underlying human cultural expressions will find this conference fascinating and stimulating."⁵⁸

Such an argument might not convince students today to take part in a colloquium, but the fact remains that on March 8, there were two hundred people in the room, including a few students from Berkeley, who decided

⁵⁷ I could not locate the compensation. It seems that the lectures were recorded by the Department of French and Italian, but they have not been found. This is according to Dean MacCannell.

⁵⁸ From the March 6, 1980, edition of *California Aggie*. I would like to thank the team of librarians at the University of California, Davis, in particular David Michalski, for their help.

to heckle Goffman's speech to protest his departure for the University of Pennsylvania. But Goffman remained unperturbed. His talk was entitled "Representational Space: A Frame Analysis"⁵⁹ and offered a frame-analysis of European cartoons, relying in particular on a technique called the "game of seven errors," which asks: What are the seven differences between two apparently identical drawings? It was his own way of doing semiotics and responding to the semioticians present. He read his notes and commented on his slides without ever asking the students to calm down. He could have interrupted himself and said something like "I can't talk over such a hub-bub," but recognizing the high stakes of the colloquium, especially for Dean MacCannell, it appears Goffman did not want to give any importance to a few provocations. After his speech, he listened to the other speakers, went for lunch with them, blending in, never drawing attention to himself.

As in Urbino or London, Goffman offered a perfectly smooth presentation. Does this mean that, as the years went by, he presented himself as more toned-down? That would be too simple an interpretation. In fact, we might well ask whether he ever behaved like a "bad boy" during his presentations. Certainly, he disliked photographers. Certainly, he always forbade recordings. Certainly, he acted out—putting on a "clown show," as MacCannell put it—when he perceived that the audience had just come to see him, not listen to him.⁶⁰ But how often did this offbeat behavior truly occur? Is it not rather the rumor mill that has multiplied and amplified a few examples? We know that Goffman was the subject of anecdotes, which were told on campus, almost underground, to show complicity with the interlocutor or to let them believe in a privileged relationship with the master. These "Goffman stories," which emerged long before his death, gave him an aura of a strange but fascinating sociologist, whose every public appearance was scrutinized.

"It Looks Like a Stalag"

In 1981, André Helbo was a young and ambitious professor of semiotics at the Université Libre de Bruxelles (ULB). He had the idea of launching an International Association for the Semiology of the Spectacle (Association internationale pour la sémiologie du spectacle [AISS]) by organizing an international colloquium that would welcome several prestigious speakers: Henri Laborit, Eugenio Barba, Annie Ubersfeld, and Goffman. André Helbo

⁵⁹ See the presentation in Manfred Kusch's symposium report (1980).

⁶⁰ Email from Dean MacCannell, December 29, 2021.

invited Goffman without knowing him personally, but Goffman immediately accepted. The AISS paid for his plane, hotel, and fees.⁶¹

The symposium took place from April 23 to 25, 1981. The guests stayed at the Sheraton, a newly opened luxury hotel that was offering promotional prices. Every morning, Helbo sent an “Orange Cab” (the company’s name) to pick them up, and Barba enjoyed the Belgian surrealism in the fact that “cab orange” was written on the orange cab.

The colloquium was held in an amphitheater at the Vrije Universiteit Brussels (VUB), ULB’s Dutch-speaking counterpart, which had just moved to a former military field. The buildings were brand new, but grim. There was not a tree in sight. Goffman remarked to Helbo: “It looks like a stalag.”

The title of Goffman’s talk was “The Lecture as Performance.”⁶² He apparently dramatized his talk by arriving ten minutes behind schedule. Everyone was waiting for him with a certain amount of anxiety, and then he emerged from the restrooms—and opened his talk on the ritual of conference timing. Between 150 and 200 people took their places in the room, many of them from outside the ULB. This included journalists, who would later manage to corner Goffman. He answered their questions, but no photos were published.

For the French-speaking Belgian public, Laborit and Barba were “monsters” of the field, and Goffman found himself somewhat overshadowed. He apparently made no attempt to get in touch with his colleagues, and even less so with ULB sociologists, who have no memory of him. Helbo would say: “He was distant, he had a withdrawn side, but not to the point of being unpleasant.” He didn’t visit Brussels; he only shuttled between his hotel and the colloquium. Low profile from beginning to end, once again.

“Hi Buddy”

Invited to Lyon, France, on May 13, 1982, by a group of family therapists, I met my colleague and friend Jacques Cosnier, who told me that Goffman was in town and would be giving a lecture the following day, at the Université Lyon II. Did I want to go with him? Of course!

The next day, we squeezed into the back row of a small, crowded room. Goffman was due to close a colloquium entitled “Microsociologie et histoire,” organized by Philippe Fritsch and Isaac Joseph. The latter was one of France’s best-known experts on the Chicago School. He introduced and

⁶¹ Zoom interview with André Helbo, February 11, 2021.

⁶² A summary of his contribution appeared under this title in 1982 in *Degrés* (no. 31), the magazine founded by André Helbo in 1973 (and which he still edits today).

thanked Goffman, who took the floor, declaring: "Due to an event beyond my control, the birth of my daughter, I have not prepared a paper." This sparked laughter in the room. But then a curious incident occurred: The translator was so moved that she explained to Joseph that she could not continue. As a result, Joseph asked if someone in the audience could come to the front and take over the translation. Cosnier took and raised my arm. That was how I found myself sitting next to Goffman, who did not seem the least bit surprised to see me: "Hi buddy." Goffman's impromptu talk went well. Not once did he ask not to be recorded or photographed.⁶³ There was no dramatic effort on his part, just a conversation between colleagues.

After the session, we did chat for a few minutes. We discovered that we were both due to participate in the same symposium in Italy a few weeks later. But, in the end, neither he nor I could make it. And we never saw each other again.

The Presentation that Did Not Occur

As president of the American Sociological Association (ASA), Goffman was meant to read his "Presidential Address" to all the participants at the annual meeting, held that year at the San Francisco Hilton Hotel, from September 6 to 10, 1982. But he was already too ill to travel. No one would read the speech for him. However, Goffman had carefully written his text over the preceding months. All he had to write after the missed presidential address was a "prefatory note" with a view to publication (Goffman, 1983). Without going into the content of this important speech, one can note its formal similarities to the text "The Lecture," read in public in 1976 and published in *Forms of Talk*: He used the same deadpan humor, the same interlocking frames, the same attempt to surprise through sudden breaks in register. One paragraph of "The Lecture" seems strangely prescient:

One can become aware of the situational work of overlaid keyings, text bracketing, and parenthetical utterances by examining the disphoric [*sic*] effects which result when circumstances require someone other than its author to read the author's talk. . . . A nonauthorial speaker, that is, someone filling in, can preface his reading with an account of why he is doing it, avow at the beginning that the "I" of the text is obviously not himself (but that he will use it anyway), and

⁶³ Goffman's impromptu talk was published in 1984, with a note explaining that "this text was written on the basis of the simultaneous French translation of Erving Goffman's presentation" (Goffman, 1984).

even during the reading, break frame and parenthetically add a comment of his own, as does an editor of printed text in an editor's footnote. But to speak a passage with irony or passion would be confusing. Whose irony? Whose passion? (Goffman, 1981, p. 180)

What the exegetes failed to notice was that two days later, on Friday, September 8 at 8:30 a.m., Goffman was to chair a "didactic seminar" on the theme of fieldwork, with Robert Emerson, Gary Alan Fine, Carol Stack, and Jason Ditton.⁶⁴ That an ASA president should want to lead a meeting for students on a Friday morning at the end of the annual meeting speaks volumes about Goffman's faith in fieldwork. His presidential address has often been referred to as his last testament. True, but we have forgotten his very last message: the field, again and again.

⁶⁴ Information available in the 1982 annual meeting program, available online at the American Sociological Association website.